50TH ANNIVERSARY

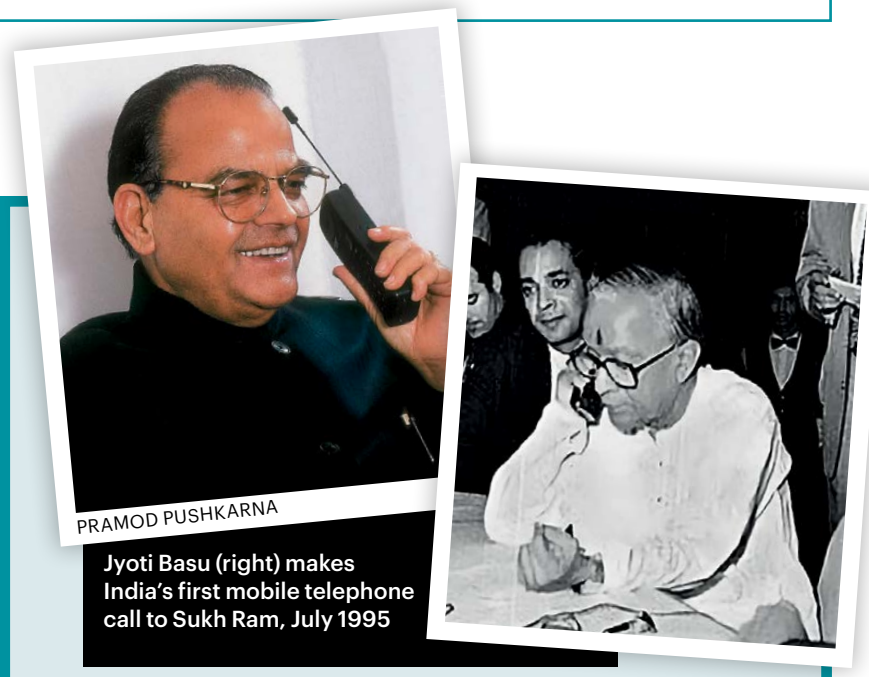
TECHNOLOGY
1995-2005

HELLO, FUTURE

Once that first mobile call was made—and the enter button pressed on the first internet search—there was no looking back for India

Two teenagers jabbering away in gaming parlance? Er, not exactly.... This is India. So the honour was reserved for the other end of the age/ social spectrum. But fate chose an unlikely duo all the same. It was July 1995 when Jyoti Basu, then a sprightly 84, rang Union telecom minister Sukh Ram, years younger but no spring chicken himself. The Marxist chief minister of West Bengal, sitting in Kolkata and using a Nokia handset on the Modi Telstra network, had just made India's very first mobile telephone call.

The telecom age wasted no time settling in. Within weeks, cellular services were rolled out across the four metros—Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai. On August 15, 1995, Videsh Sanchar Nigam Ltd (VSNL)



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

Jyoti Basu (right) makes India's first mobile telephone call to Sukh Ram, July 1995



The Emergence of the Cellerati | *May. 11, 1998*

"Only into the third year of its introduction in the metros, and just a few months in other cities, the cell phone is already an integral part of the urban landscape... cobbling up a new class of the "cellerati".... With the number of mobile phones touching a million in the April-June quarter... the cell phone era has dawned."